



Your trusted source for non-toxic living

THE CLEAN MEAT DIRECTORY

10 Safe Chicken Brands to Buy Today

*Your 'organic' chicken might be bathed in chlorine.
These brands do it differently.*



INSIDE: 10 verified air-chilled, pasture-raised chicken brands with where to buy them



The Dirty Truth About 'Clean' Chicken

Walk into any grocery store and you will find chicken labels covered with reassuring words: organic, natural, hormone-free, humanely raised. What those labels rarely mention is how that chicken was processed after slaughter.

The overwhelming majority of chicken sold in America goes through a water-chilling process where birds are submerged in large communal tanks of cold water treated with chlorine or other antimicrobial chemicals. This method is fast and cheap for processors, but it means your chicken is absorbing water (adding to the weight you pay for) along with chemical residues and potential cross-contamination from thousands of other birds.

The alternative is air-chilling, where birds are cooled individually in refrigerated chambers with no water contact whatsoever. This process takes longer and costs more, which is why most conventional producers avoid it. But the result is cleaner chicken with better texture, no added water weight, and zero chemical bath residue.

We have done the research so you can skip the detective work and head straight to the checkout line with confidence. These ten brands meet our standards for truly clean chicken: air-chilled processing, pasture-raised or free-range conditions, and transparent sourcing practices.



CHLORINE BATH WARNING SIGNS

If the label does not specifically say 'air-chilled,' assume the chicken was water-chilled with chemical treatment. Terms like 'natural,' 'organic,' and even 'no antibiotics' tell you nothing about the chilling method. Always look for the words 'air-chilled' on the package itself.



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1. Bell & Evans

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ No Antibiotics Ever ✓ Humanely Raised

Bell & Evans has been a pioneer in air-chilled chicken since the 1990s, long before most consumers knew the difference. Their birds are raised on family farms in Pennsylvania with access to sunlight and outdoor areas, fed an all-vegetable diet with no animal byproducts, and processed in their own dedicated facilities.

Where to Buy: Whole Foods, Wegmans, ShopRite, Stop & Shop, Giant, and most natural food stores. Also available direct at bellandevans.com.

2. Mary's Free Range

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Free Range ✓ Organic Options

Mary's Free Range chickens roam freely on California farms with plenty of outdoor access. They offer both conventional and certified organic lines, all air-chilled. Their heritage breed options provide exceptional flavour for those willing to pay a premium.

Where to Buy: Whole Foods, Sprouts, Bristol Farms, Erewhon, and natural grocers across the West Coast. Expanding nationally through specialty retailers.

3. White Oak Pastures

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Pasture-Raised ✓ Regenerative Farm

White Oak Pastures operates a zero-waste regenerative farm in Bluffton, Georgia, where chickens live on open pastures alongside cattle in a rotational grazing system. They process on-site at their own USDA-inspected facility using air-chilling methods. This is about as close to your great-grandparents' chicken as you can get.

Where to Buy: Whole Foods (Southeast), direct from whiteoakpastures.com with nationwide shipping. Use code LIFEUNTOX for a discount.

4. Cooks Venture

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Pasture-Raised ✓ Heritage Breed

Cooks Venture raises their proprietary Pioneer breed chicken on regenerative pastures in Arkansas. These slow-growing heritage birds develop richer flavour than conventional breeds.

All processing is air-chilled at their own facility, and they maintain complete control over the supply chain from hatchery to package.

Where to Buy: Direct from cooksventure.com with nationwide shipping. Select Whole Foods locations. Butcher Box subscription service.

5. Pasturebird

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Pasture-Raised ✓ Moved Daily

Pasturebird moves their chickens to fresh pasture every single day using mobile shelters, giving birds constant access to new grass, bugs, and sunshine. Based in Southern California, they have scaled pasture-raised production while maintaining strict air-chilled processing standards.

Where to Buy: Erewhon, Bristol Farms, Lazy Acres, and select California retailers. Direct shipping via pasturebird.com.

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6. Vital Farms

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Pasture-Raised ✓ Certified Humane

Vital Farms built their reputation on pasture-raised eggs, and they apply the same ethical standards to their chicken. Birds are raised on partner farms with at least 108 square feet of outdoor pasture per bird, far exceeding organic requirements. All processing is air-chilled.

Where to Buy: Whole Foods, Sprouts, Target (select locations), Kroger, Publix, and most major grocery chains with natural sections.

7. Farmer Focus

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Certified Organic ✓ Farmer-Owned

Farmer Focus is owned by the farmers who raise the birds, ensuring higher welfare standards and complete transparency. Based in Virginia's Shenandoah Valley, they offer both organic and humanely raised options, all air-chilled. Their website lets you trace your chicken back to the specific farm where it was raised.

Where to Buy: Whole Foods, Wegmans, Harris Teeter, Publix, and growing availability on the East Coast. Direct shipping via farmerfocus.com.

8. Joyce Farms

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ Free Range ✓ Heritage Breeds

Joyce Farms in North Carolina specialises in heritage breed poultry, including their acclaimed Poulet Rouge chicken. These slow-growing birds develop complex flavour profiles similar to what you would find in France, and all processing is strictly air-chilled. This is the brand chefs seek out for exceptional quality.

Where to Buy: Direct from joycefarms.com, select Whole Foods, and specialty butcher shops. Popular with restaurant chefs and available through food service distributors.

9. Shenandoah Valley Organic

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ USDA Organic ✓ 100% Traceable

Shenandoah Valley Organic chickens are raised on small family farms in Virginia with access to outdoors and fed certified organic feed. Their air-chilled processing and complete farm-to-fork traceability set them apart from larger organic producers who cut corners on processing methods.

Where to Buy: Whole Foods, MOM's Organic Market, and specialty grocers throughout the Mid-Atlantic region.

10. Perdue Harvestland (Organic Air-Chilled Line)

✓ Air-Chilled ✓ USDA Organic ✓ Widely Available

Perdue's Harvestland organic air-chilled line offers clean chicken at mainstream prices and availability. While Perdue has conventional lines that use water-chilling, their specifically labeled 'air-chilled' organic products meet our standards. Look carefully at the package to confirm air-chilled processing.

Where to Buy: Walmart, Costco, Kroger, Safeway, and most major grocery chains nationwide. The most accessible option on this list.



Quick Reference: Where to Shop

Use this at-a-glance guide to find clean chicken wherever you shop:

STORE	CLEAN BRANDS AVAILABLE
Whole Foods	Bell & Evans, Mary's, Vital Farms, Farmer Focus, Joyce Farms
Wegmans	Bell & Evans, Farmer Focus
Sprouts	Mary's Free Range, Vital Farms
Target	Vital Farms (select locations)
Walmart / Costco	Perdue Harvestland Organic Air-Chilled
Online Direct	White Oak Pastures, Cooks Venture, Pasturebird, Joyce Farms

How to Verify Any Brand

When shopping for chicken beyond this list, use these verification steps:

1. **Look for 'Air-Chilled' on the front of the package.** This is the most important factor. No air-chilled label means water-chilled with chemicals.
2. **Check for third-party certifications.** Certified Humane, Animal Welfare Approved, and Global Animal Partnership ratings indicate higher standards.
3. **Research the brand website.** Transparent companies openly discuss their processing methods. If they hide this information, there is usually a reason.
4. **Compare water retention.** Water-chilled chicken releases liquid when cooking. Air-chilled chicken holds its weight and develops better browning.

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This guide is for educational purposes only. Brand availability may vary by location.

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